Despite this direct and structured communication though, the discipline and the goals hard-wired into our systems, a silliness appears alongside it. Swanny has decided, alongside Barney Douglas, who has flown out with us as an in-house video producer – years before he becomes a film director – that he is going to do an Ashes Diary. Twitter has just been invented and we are all on it, but no one takes it remotely seriously. There's no tweeting out with your team or constant anxiety about messaging in keeping with your 'brand'. No one knows what they are doing; it's just random thoughts, whatever comes into your head, thrown into the ether. Swanny and Barney take to the diaries with a similar attitude – a series of thrown together 'sketches' of what life is like on tour. Bits are thrown together where Swanny is pretending he's just done a thousand press-ups or on the phone to a doctor who is telling him to 'rub the cream all over the affected area'.

After we save the first Test, escaping a losing situation that would usually be regarded with fear and finger-pointing by the English media, Swanny tells the camera that it was 'nice to see someone who runs like Woody from *Toy Story* get a double hundred for England'. I get caught up in it and begin to appear regularly as a sort of straight man, comedic sidekick. We don't think anyone will watch to begin with, so there's a real freedom to it and we are spending bus journeys to and from training, writing ideas and sketches together. It turns out people do like them, and back home the show is receiving a lot of YouTube views. Encouraged by this, it gets more and more slapstick and out there with every episode. I think of myself channelling all the hours in front of the television watching Victoria Wood or *Red Dwarf* or Lee Evans and the days and time between cricket become less days of holding-pen homesickness and more creative licence to be as innocently stupid as we possibly can.

Being with Swanny begins to fill me with the same feeling as meeting Gaz and Dave in Burnley. Gaz and Swanny are extremely similar personalities. His confidence and exuberance and ability to connect with people has a reassuring effect on me. I often wish I could be more like them in public situations, but don't feel heavy or awkward in their presence either when we are just killing time. It's something that shouldn't be rare to find but, for me, really is. With the series 0-0 after one Test, Swanny does a bit to camera, telling everyone at home that even though the media think we have an unhealthy team ethic, that we are too tight-knit, it couldn't be